

Incident Response Checklist

A practical first-response outline, aligned to the NIST IR lifecycle

1. Preparation (before an incident)

- Maintain an up-to-date asset inventory and network diagram.
- Keep contact lists current: IT, legal, leadership, external IR support.
- Ensure logging is centralized and retained long enough to be useful.
- Run tabletop exercises at least annually.

2. Identification

- Record exactly what was observed, when, and by whom.
- Determine scope: which systems, accounts, or data appear affected.
- Classify severity and assign an incident owner.
- Preserve volatile evidence before it's lost (memory, active connections, logs).

3. Containment

- Apply short-term containment first (isolate the host/account) without destroying evidence.
- Take forensic images before wiping or rebuilding anything.
- Rotate credentials that may be compromised.
- Document every containment action taken, with timestamps.

4. Eradication

- Identify and remove the root cause, not just the symptom.
- Patch the vulnerability or misconfiguration that allowed entry.
- Scan related systems for the same indicator of compromise.

5. Recovery

- Restore systems from known-clean backups where possible.
- Monitor restored systems closely for recurrence.
- Confirm normal business functions before formally closing the incident.

6. Lessons learned

- Hold a blameless post-incident review within two weeks.
 - Update playbooks, detections, and training based on what was learned.
 - Track remediation items to completion, not just to assignment.
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